

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Home fire

HOME BUILDING / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Get out, stay out and call emergency services from outside. Use the nearest safe exit, stay low beneath smoke, and close doors behind you if possible. Do not stop for belongings or go back inside for people or pets; tell firefighters where they may be.

Do now.

**Leave immediately**

01

Follow the escape route and use stairs, not elevators. Check doors for heat before opening; use another exit if unsafe.

**If the exit is blocked**

02

Close doors between you and fire, call emergency services with your location and signal from a window.

**Meet outside**

03

Account for everyone at the meeting point and report missing people to firefighters.

**Stay outside**

04

Do not reenter until the fire department permits it.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Escape immediately, gather outside and keep the exit area clear. If trapped, close the door between you and smoke, signal from a window and send your exact location if possible. Do not reenter because the fire seems quiet or because firefighters have not arrived.

Watch for.

An extinguisher attempt must never delay escape or block your exit.

People & practical needs.

Practice the route with children and anyone needing movement assistance. Agree on a nearby meeting point and who will supervise dependents once outside. Include a second safe way out when the building permits it; never block an exit with stored supplies.

Keep essentials within reach.

Prioritize supplies named in this guide that are usable by the person who needs them. Keep the checklist and relevant contact details accessible. Check carrying capacity, storage and equipment instructions in advance; collecting equipment must not delay the immediate protective action.

Next decisions.

Install and test smoke alarms and practice two ways out with the household. Plan assistance for children and people with mobility needs.

Questions in the field.

Can I retrieve a phone or a pet?

Do not delay escape or reenter for belongings or animals. Once outside, tell responders where anyone may remain. Keep the household assembly point clear so missing people can be identified without people searching inside.

The exit is blocked - what then?

Do not force a hot door or a route filling with smoke. Close doors between you and the fire, call and signal your exact location. A high-rise needs its building-specific plan; use the Apartment & high-rise fire guide rather than guessing at an elevator or window escape.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

Home fire · official guidance

<https://www.usfa.fema.gov/prevention/home-fires/prepare-for-fire/>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/home-fire/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.